



# CITY OF DAVID

## STUDIES OF ANCIENT JERUSALEM

The 25<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference | Editor: Eyal Meiron

## **City of David Studies of Ancient Jerusalem**

The 25<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference

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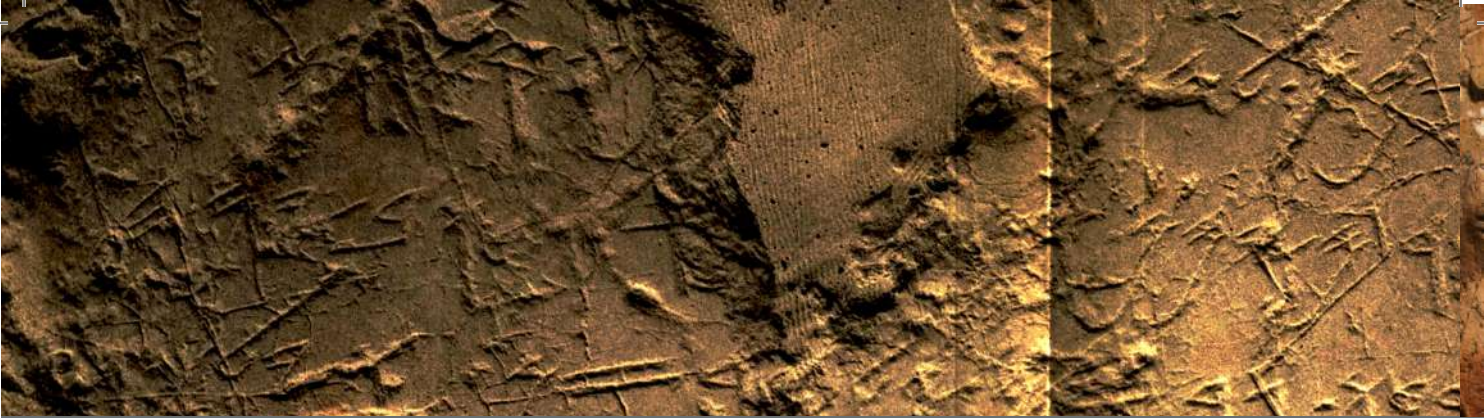
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## New archaeological discoveries in the excavations of Birket al-Hamra in Jerusalem

———— Nahshon Szanton\* Filip Vukosavović\*\* and Itamar Berko\*\* ————

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This article offers a preliminary report and a description of the findings in the new excavations conducted at the Birket al-Hamra site in the years 2023–2024. The site is located at the southern outlet of the Tyropoeon Valley. It is bounded to the east by a large water dam, the remains of which were partially uncovered in previous excavations. During the excavation, it became clear that the monumental staircase uncovered by Ronny Reich and Eli Shukron in the northern part of Birket al-Hamra does not continue south into the center of the topographic depression of this pool. The article discusses the possible connection between the uncovered remains and an possible entertainment structure built by King Herod as part of the foundation of the quinquennial celebrations in honor of Emperor Augustus.

## ■ Introduction

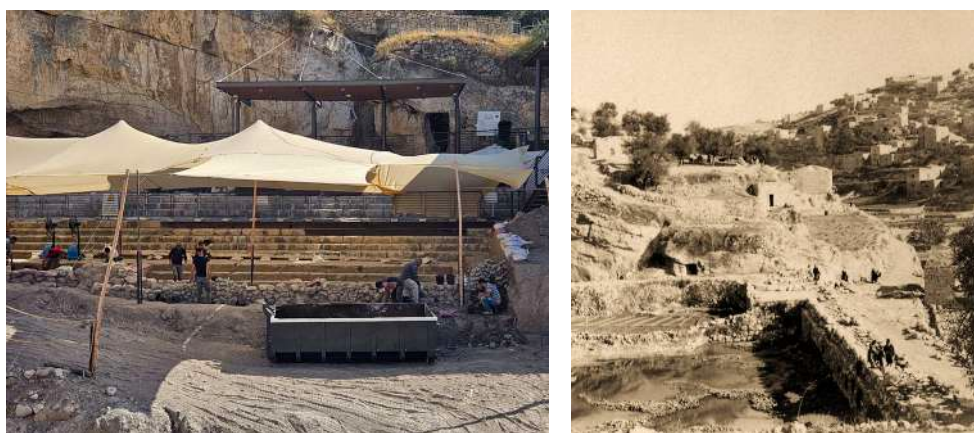
Since April 2023, a rescue excavation has been conducted in the Silwan neighborhood of Jerusalem, in the area of "Birket al-Hamra."<sup>1</sup> The excavation, on behalf of the Israel Antiquities Authority, in cooperation with the Nature and Parks Authority and funded by the City of David Foundation (Elad), was directed in 2023 by N. Szanton and I. Berko (IAA permit A-9518) and in 2024 by F. Vukosavović and I. Berko (IAA permit A-9742). The excavation was carried out in two areas: Area A – at the southernmost end of the Tyropoeon valley where there is a topographic depression known as "Birket el-Hamra (المسيح الأحمر)"; and Area B – south of Silwan Pool. The excavation in Area B is only at its beginning and will not be included in this article.

The Birket al-Hamra site is known from several studies conducted since the 19th century, from which one can learn about the use of the pool for irrigated agriculture (Figure 1). In the picture from 1899, one can see that the pool area is full of rainwater (Figure 2). These photos indicate that an orchard or tree plantation on the site only began to develop during the 20th century. In pictures from 1907 the site is already demarcated by a new wall surrounding it (a wall that has been preserved to this day), but trees or an orchard are still not found there (Patton 1907).

1 The excavation was assisted by: Amit Re'em, Neria Sapir, Kfir Arviv and Moran Hagbi (Jerusalem District), Nissan Nehama (administration), Benjamin Storch and Itamar Berko (area supervision), Eitan Klein (looting), Shai Halevi (photography and models), Vadim Essman (drafting and surveying), Johanna Regev (Carbon 14), Lee Pery Gal (archaeozoology), Itamar Taxel and Yehuda Rapuano (ceramics), Yotam Asscher and Whitley Straman (analytical laboratory). Additional thanks go to Kobi Gur-Arie, Baruch Rabi and Yehuda Eitan (project management).

In January 2023, it was decided to develop the Birket al-Hamra site for tourism. To this end, trial excavations were first conducted on behalf of the Israel Antiquities Authority by one of the authors (N. Szanton) in the lowest and easternmost part of the site. Several trenches were made along and across the area, and except for a few terrace walls that were exposed inside, as well as a plastered installation from the Ottoman period (Figure 3), it became clear that up to a depth of 2–2.5 m the upper part of the entire examined area was covered with a layer of field stones (about half a meter thick) and below with brown-gray soil that is almost entirely free of rocks or any layering (Figure 4).

In the trench near the center of the western (inner) side of the dam wall, an archaeological layer was uncovered at a depth of 2.5 m from the surface, and it was decided to remove the soil above it and above the terraces with mechanical tools. The absence of significant architectural remains in the trial trenches raised doubts about the southern continuation of the stairway uncovered by Reich and Shukron in the northern wing of Birket al-Hamra. Therefore, it was decided to continue the excavation manually in the area between the northern staircase and the dam wall. In this area, six excavation squares were opened, bordered in the north by the staircase uncovered by Reich and Shukron, to the west by the Ottoman plastered installation, and to the east by the dam wall (Figure 5). The preparation of the area for the excavation included the removal of some of the terraces on the site. As a result, the remains of a large building were exposed in the southwest corner of the excavation area. This structure was documented and covered due to engineering



**Figure 1 a-b:** Top- a view to the northeast of Birket al-Hamra at the end of the 19th century (photo courtesy of Shimon Gibson's photo archive). Bottom- a terrace wall separates the plots in the north from the swamp to the south of it. We excavated this wall (W35), as seen in the photo below (photo: Nahshon Szanton).



**Figure 2.** A view of the southeast corner of Birket al-Hamra in 1899. Note the dam wall and the seasonal lake. The large tree in the picture's foreground is traditionally called the "Isaiah Tree." At the bottom of the photo, a man stands on top of W35; see also Figure 1 (photo courtesy of Shimon Gibson's photo archive).

needs but is expected to be excavated in the future.

The northern part of the pool, which is located directly below the southern cliff of the Southeastern Ridge (City of David), was excavated, as mentioned above, by Reich and Shukron (2005). They uncovered a monumental staircase with two construction stages, descending towards the center of the site of Birket al-Hamra, most of which remained outside the boundaries of their excavation, as well as a wall on the north-south axis (the dam wall) whose construction preceded the staircase. The first stage of the staircase was dated to the middle of the first century BCE, based on coins



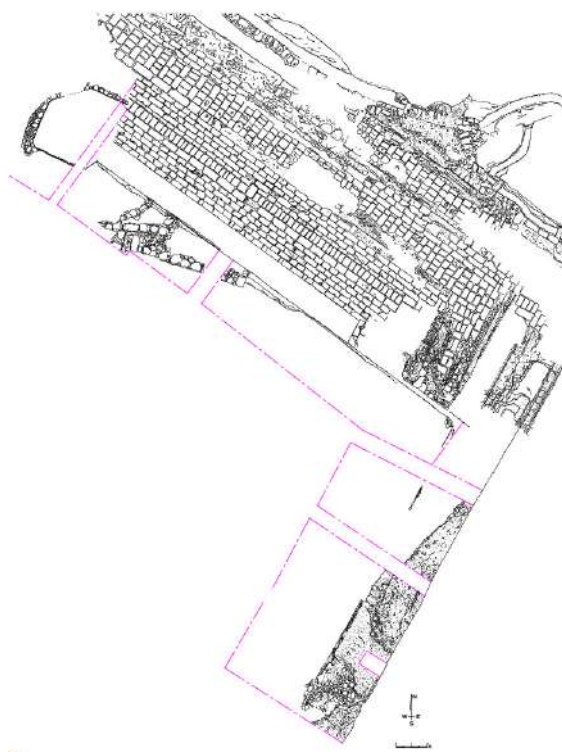
**Figure 3.** View to the northwest of plastered installation L23 (photo: Nahshon Szanton).

**Figure 4.** View to the south of a cross section of soil above the surface level of the manual excavation. In the upper part of the section, a layer of field stones is visible, and below it, there is a very thick layer of soil without additional layering (photo: Nahshon Szanton).



of King 'Yanai' that were sealed inside the foundation of these stairs. The second phase built from ashlar stones was dated by them to the end of the Second Temple period (Reich and Shukron 2005:93). They dated the wall on the north-south axis to the end of the Iron Age based on a single indicative sherd from this period found in the plaster that covered

the western face of the wall and recognized it as the dam wall of the pool. They restored the staircase from the end of the Second Temple period to the full width and length of Birket al-Hamra (Figure 6) and identified this pool with the historical Siloam Pool (Shukron and Reich 2005:37–40). However, in our opinion, Birket al-Hamra should be identified with "Solomon's Pool" and the Silwan Pool at the outlet of the Siloam with the "Siloam Pool" (see further Szanton 2023).



**Figure 5.** Plan of squares and excavation areas (drawing and measurement: Vadim Essman, IAA).

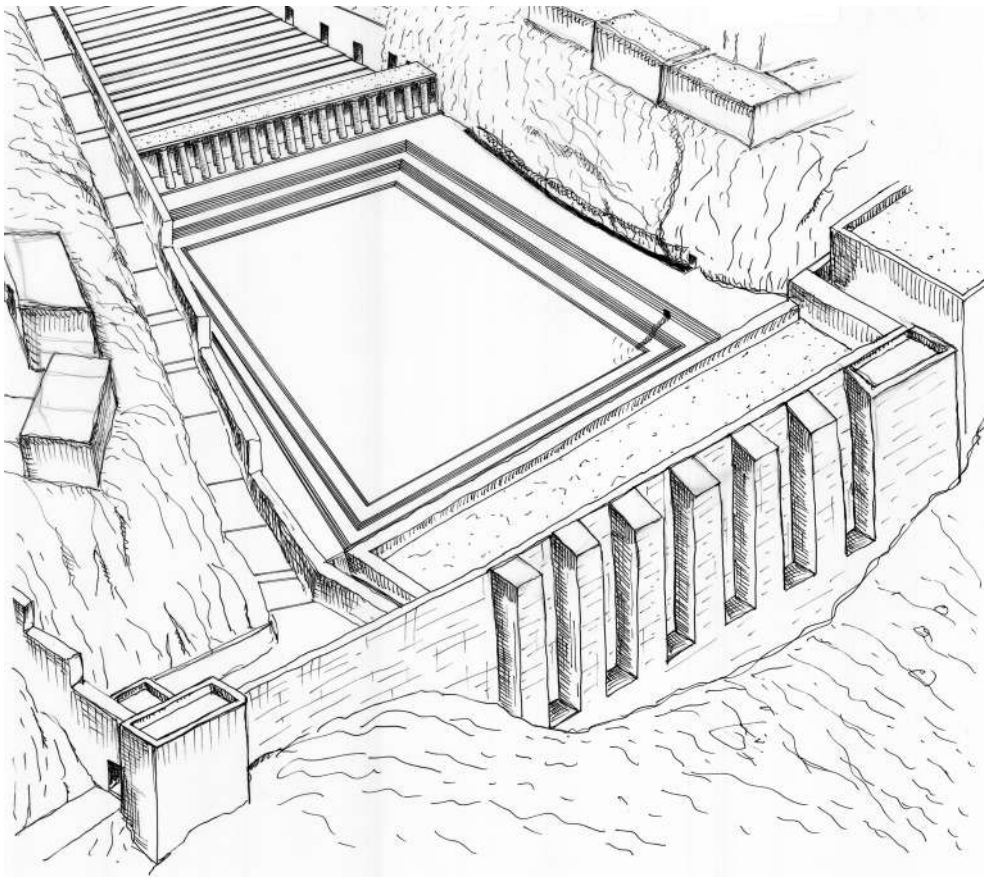
## ■ The New Excavations (2023–2024)

The excavation revealed four main strata. The latest stratum is from the Ottoman period (Stratum 1), under which a layer from the Ayyubid-Mamluk period was exposed (Stratum 2). This article will focus on describing the remains from the two earliest strata uncovered so far at the site (Strata 3, 4).

### **Stratum 3a-b** (second half of the first century BCE–first century CE)

The monumental staircase was uncovered by Reich and Shukron at the northern end of Birket al-Hamra, directly below the southern cliff of the City of David. Its northern wing is wide and leans against the cliff. The staircase in the east abutted (leaned against) the western face of the dam wall and turned at an angle close to 90 degrees to the south. A similar turn towards the south was revealed in the west, although it was only exposed in a limited area. The architectural plan obtained from this excavation brought up an array of four sets of five-step stairs (*scalae*) each with three wide walkways (*praecinctions*) between them. The center of the topographic depression of Birket al-Hamra remained outside the limits of the excavation. Parallel water installations with the same architectural plan for the staircases, although much smaller in size, were uncovered in early Roman Jerusalem at the Ophel (Mazar 2018), near Wilson's Arch (Bahat 2013: 91–105) and in the Jewish Quarter (Geva 2017). The topographical parameters (the dam wall in the east, the cliff of the City of David hill in the north, and a paved expansion in the west) that the pool related to and the typology of the water facilities of the same period from Jerusalem led Reich and Shukron to propose and reconstruct the complete outline of the pool as one that fills the entire topographic depression in which Birket al-Hamra is located, which they suggested identifying with the historical Siloam Pool (Reich and Shukron 2005; Shukron and Reich 2005; Reich and Shukron 2011). In the current excavation, it turned out that the lowest staircase that Reich and Shukron began to uncover included six steps. At their lower end is about 1.5 m wide sidewalk (630.25 m) plastered with two layers of plaster. The lower plastered walkway was the end of the set of stairs, and at its end was a plastered vertical wall (W185) (Figure 7). The vertical wall in the current excavation was exposed to a maximum height of about 3 m and was not exposed to its full height, except in its western part, where it is built on top of the bedrock that was quarried to conform to it. The bedrock descends steeply in the direction of the valley, meaning that the construction of the pool complex was done in accordance to the topography of the southeast end of

the Tyropoeon Valley while adjusting the rock in the quarry for the construction of the monumental staircase above it. The eastern wing of the staircase continues to the south until its southern edge aligns with southern edge of the lowest walkway (Figures 8–9). The construction here is neat and straight, without signs of robbed or broken stones. To achieve a smooth and uniform surface, the entire vertical face was covered with light



**Figure 6.** Reconstruction of the Siloam Pool at the Birket al-Hamra site, according to Reich and Shukron (Reich 2011: Fig. 160; drawing by XXXX XXXX).



**Figure 7.** On the left side of the photo, the staircase and the lower walkway built on the bedrock, and to the south of them are layers of ash and the remains of a building, probably from the Ayyubid-Mamluk period that was built inside the area of the pool (photo: Nahshon Szanton).



**Figure 8.** The end of the monumental staircase and the lower walkway. Note the straight and even line between the end of the eastern staircase in the photo's foreground and the end of the lower walkway (photo: Nahshon Szanton).



**Figure 9.** The end of the eastern staircase above the head-and-stretcher course of ashlar stones, aligned with the end of the lower step. Note the depth of the plastered pool on the northern wall (photo: Nahshon Szanton).

gray plaster that was partially preserved in situ.

### Layer 3c (Hellenistic period)

While descending deeper into the dirt along the southern edge of the staircase, we uncovered the stone courses on top of which the eastern wing was built. Looking at these stairs, it was impossible to distinguish two separate construction phases since the early phase also included the use of large building stones. At the level of the lowest walkway, which was

exposed in the current excavation, a change was noticed in the courses of stones on which the eastern wing was built. At this level, a 10 m long course was exposed, built of large ashlar stones dressed with finely carved margins and a rough but not prominent center. The stones are aligned in the header-and-stretcher technique (Fig. 10). Despite the nature of the stones and the way they were built, it is evident that these are stones that were brought to the site in secondary use since the faces of the stones arranged as "heads" are completely smoothed without frame and protruding center. In addition, the ends of the stones are slightly broken, there are spaces between stones that are filled in with small stones, and there is also a lack of uniformity in the upper layer of the stones, creating an uneven level. The use of ashlar stones of this type is found in construction in Jerusalem along the first wall (for parallels, see Geva 1985: 34–33; Zelinger 2008:127; Bliss and Dickie 1898: Pl. V). The method of laying stones of this type in a head-and-stretcher pattern is known in Jerusalem from fortifications attributed to the Seleucid Citadel (Ben-Ami and Tchekhanovets 2015:315; Zilberstein 2023:39.4). To the knowledge of the authors, no site made use of courses in this technique and arrangement for the building of foundations above which there is a different (and even inferior) type of construction. Thus, it can be concluded that this course manifests a separate and earlier construction phase than the eastern staircase built above it. The east end of the head-and-stretcher course stops about four meters in front of the ancient dam wall, and the

courses above and below also stop in the same manner. At this initial stage, it is evident that this is a robbery of the top of a wall from an earlier phase built here on a north-south axis (Stratum 4 below). During the robbery, two different layers of soil were deposited. The upper one contains ceramics from the Ottoman period, while the lower one contains ceramics from the Mamluk period. It should be noted that the northern part of these layers had already been excavated and documented by Reich and Shukron in the area between the inside and diagonal face of the staircase and the western face of the dam wall (Shukron and Reich 2005:34). Reich and Shukron thought that this was perhaps a late disturbance caused by researchers such as Guthe or Bliss and Dickie and proposed digging a probe into the “nearby garden,” that is, in the Birket al-Hamra, in an area that is not disturbed (*ibid.*). In our excavation in the Birket al-Hamra to the south, in the area between the dam wall and the earth layers that abutted the remains of the staircase, a similar layer was exposed, containing pottery from a similar period. Therefore, it is not possible to interpret them as “disturbances” made by the early excavators of the site. The fact that directly above the looted area and the later layers of soil, a structure from the Ottoman period was built, suggests the time when the stones were looted and the area was leveled.<sup>2</sup>



**Figure 10.** The layer of ashlar stones built in header-and-stretcher technique and above it the staircase structure (photo: Shai Halevi).

<sup>2</sup> This building is currently used as the guard post at the entrance from the Kidron Channel to the Siloam Pool site.

### Stratum 4 (Persian-Hellenistic period?)

Under the missing eastern end of the header-and-stretcher course from Stratum 3c and under the layers of soil that filled the robber trench (see above), a wall on a north-south axis was exposed, and its width appears to reach the western face of the dam wall.<sup>3</sup> It seems that this wall rose to a greater height before being robbed. Its outer (western) face relates to the course of header-and-stretcher stones (Stratum 3c above). The wall is built of large stones held together by hard bonding material. To date, the top part of the pool's eastern wall has been exposed along the entire length of the dam, with its top and western face plastered. The upper thickness of the pool wall up to the western face of the dam wall exposed in the excavation is about 3.2 m. Its complete plan, original height, and relation to the dam wall are still unclear. In a more southern area excavated in 2024, the looted top of this wall was exposed, where the negatives embedded in the hard bonding material were preserved, marking the outline of the stones that were displaced from its top and reaching the plastered exterior face of the wall. The courses of the wall gradually widen toward the base of the wall, and therefore, the plaster on the outer western face is sloping and built diagonally towards the inside of the pool. The plaster here was preserved in several layers, some of which are thick (Fig. 11). Another thick mass of plaster was uncovered in the northwest corner of the pool where the staircase abuts the pool wall. It should be noted that in Reich and Shukron's excavation, the northern part of this wall was documented directly below the staircase built above it. The excavation in a dark and narrow space made it difficult for Reich and Shukron to distinguish between the parts of the top of a wall built of large stones and the steps in the bedrock. Therefore, they believed that the inner face of the staircase was built sloping diagonally directly on top of the rock (Shukron and Reich 2005:34). However, in practice, it was built directly on the western face of the eastern pool wall that preceded it.



**Figure 11.** Looking south onto the diagonal layer of plaster covering the outer face of W114 (Photo: Nahshon Szanton).

3 The excavation at the site was halted due to its great depth and water draining into the area, so the stratigraphic relationship between the two walls has not yet been clarified.

The plastered pool exposed on top of the ancient dam wall may also be added to this construction phase (Greenhut and Mazor 2020). The plaster was sampled for dating using the carbon 14 method. Its results (520–200 BCE) indicate that it was built in the Persian-early Hellenistic period (Boaretto 2020:79).

## ■ Discussion

In the southern area of the Tyropoeon Valley, there were four pools in total, dating to the Early Roman period: two small-sized pools designed to collect excess water, one northeast of the Birket al-Hamra (Adan-Bayweitz 1979) and one southeast of the Birket al-Hamra excavated by Guthe (1881) and Bliss and Dickie (1898), and fully exposed in several later excavations (Weksler-Bdolah and Szanton 2014; Weksler-Bdolah and Hagbi 2022; Greenhut and Mazor 2020); the Silwan Pool which was previously identified as the Siloam Pool (Guthe 1882; Bliss and Dickie 1898); and the Birket al-Hamra, which revealed a monumental staircase was identified by Reich and Shukron as the Siloam Pool (Shukron and Reich 2005; Reich and Shukron 2011), although recently the Silwan Pool was re-identified as the site of the Siloam Pool (Szanton 2023).

The monumental staircase uncovered by Reich and Shukron at the northern side of the Birket al-Hamra consists of three wings—west, north and east—and each wing consists of three section. Each section consists of five steps, with a wide walkway between the sections. Unlike the northern wing, only the northern ends of the western and eastern wings were uncovered. It was assumed that both wings continued southward at an angle close to 90 degrees while preserving the architecture of the staircase sections (for detailed documentation, Shukron and Reich 2005). This architectural plan with the topographic depression of the site and the dam wall to the east, the cliff of the City of David Hill to the north, a paved square to the west (Shukron and Reich 2005), and the western hill to the south led Reich and Shukron to reconstruct the complete outline of the staircase of the entire site of Birket al-Hamra akin to models of similar water facilities with a spiral staircase known in Early Roman-period Jerusalem (Bahat 2013:91–105; Geva 2017; Mazar 2018).

However, in the current excavation, it became clear that the eastern wing of the staircase uncovered by Reich and Shukron does not continue to the full extent of Birket al-Hamra but only another 3 m to the south, where it ends in a long walkway built over a tall, plastered vertical wall (W185). At the eastern end of the monumental staircase next to Reich and Shukron's dam wall, as mentioned, a construction section in the header-and-

stretcher technique was exposed on an east-west axis, which hints at another construction phase that existed here, which for now remains unclear (Stratum 3c). Under the eastern end of this unique course, a new wall (W114) on a north-south axis was exposed. Wall W185A forms a corner with W114, with a thick layer of plaster wrapping around both. At this stage, it can be said that these wide and plastered walls are the walls of an ancient pool that existed on the site of Birket al-Hamra, and for now, it seems that a monumental staircase was built only in its northern wing. Therefore, the monumental staircase Reich



**Figure 12 a, b:** The construction phases in Stratum 3: above- the ashlar stone phase (3a), below- the plastered construction phase that preceded it (3b) after the stone paving and the stone foundation were dismantled. Note the height of the plastered rise (3b), which reaches half a meter! (Photo: Nahshon Szanton).

and Shukron uncovered at the foot of the hill of the City of David must be separated from the remains of the pool we uncovered slightly further south. If so, what were the staircases used for, and why were they built this way? Since the western wing has not yet been excavated, it seems this question should be left open, although clues are showing that these are not stairs but seats. Seats played an important role in ceremonial spaces of the Greek world (Hollinshead 2012), as well as stairs (*ibid.*), as can be learned from the nearby stepped street that led to the Temple Mount (Szanton et al. 2020).

As part of the completion of the exposure of the eastern wing of the monumental staircase and its documentation, it was

decided to remove two slabs from the paving stones (Stratum 3a) to obtain a complete architectural sequence of the plastered phase that preceded it (Stratum 3b). Removing the stones involved a lot of effort, as they were fixed in their place with a hard bonding material. However, the plastered construction phase was well preserved under the stones, and its shape could be architecturally defined in relation to the paved phase built above it. It turned out that the plastered phase reached a height of half a meter! (Figure 12). This height does not correspond to the height of stairs but to seats. Moreover, the dimensions of the plastered phase largely determined the dimensions of the ashlar stone phase and the stone foundation underneath, which were built later, matching them and their dimensions. For this reason, the height of its courses is smaller, but it likely continued to be used in the same manner. Therefore, it can be assumed that the two phases were used for sitting and not as a staircase or that in the later stage (the ashlar stage), the purpose of the previous building was changed.

Monumental public seat buildings from the late Hellenistic period and throughout the Early Roman period are known from around the Roman Empire in various forms. The most prominent of these are known as theater buildings, amphitheaters, and hippodromes. These three types of buildings are mentioned by Josephus, who notes that a "theater" and an "amphitheater" were built in Jerusalem by Herod in 27 BCE as part of the five-year celebrations in honor of Emperor Augustus (*Antiquities* 10: 268–275). These festivities were associated with Augustus' victory in the famous naval battle at Actium, and the festival in honor of Augustus was indeed celebrated at Actium the previous year on September 28 BCE (Burrell 2020: 50–51). Descriptions of these structures given by Josephus were discussed in the studies about the Roman East in general (Welch 1998) and about Jerusalem in particular (Weiss 2015).

The "five-year period" games of Herod were held in Caesarea (*Antiquities* 15:137–138) but also in Jerusalem (*Antiquities* 15:268–275). For games and competitions, a theater and an amphitheater were built in the city "on plain ground" (*ibid.*). However, later horse racing competitions are also mentioned (*ibid.* 271), as are gladiator fights (*ibid.* 274). Horse racing usually took place in another building, known as a hippodrome, and indeed, the hippodrome is mentioned by Josephus elsewhere as a structure that existed in Jerusalem during the uprising that broke out with the death of Herod in 4 BCE (*Jewish War*:2:44; *Antiquities* 17:255). The description of the games in Jerusalem corresponds to the description in Caesarea, and they were generally divided into three types, which correspond to three different amusement buildings:

1. Competition of plays and music performances (theater).
2. Gladiator fights (amphitheater).
3. Horse racing (hippodrome).

The games in Jerusalem and Caesarea were named "Isactium" after the victory in the battle of Actium (Schwartz 1989:27, note 24). The games in Caesarea date to /10 or even 11 BCE (for further discussion and references, see Schwartz 1989:29, note 33), but in Jerusalem, the games and buildings are mentioned in connection with the events of 25–27 BCE (Schürer 1973:290, 304). The shows and competitions that were foreign to Jewish culture eventually led to an assassination attempt on Herod, which failed (Antiquities 10:268, 280–291) and may not have existed for long afterward, if at all. Perhaps this is why the festival of Isactium and these amusement buildings are hardly mentioned later. Maybe this is also the reason why Herod later chose to renew and establish the "Isactium" celebrations in honor of Augustus in Caesarea, which was later founded as a new city with a distinct foreign character. It should be remembered that aside from Jerusalem and Caesarea, these performances were not held anywhere or in any other city in Judea. Therefore, it can be assumed that the success of the performances in Caesarea compensated for the failure of their presentation in Jerusalem. One way or another, the dating of the structure of the seats from Stratum 3a-b can correspond to the first decades of King Herod's reign.

Josephus' descriptions indicate that in these buildings in Jerusalem, inscriptions and images of victory were presented in honor of the emperor ("*tropaea*"), and sports and entertainment activities were held there, as mentioned above, as well as horse and gladiator competitions (Antiquities 10:271–272, 276–279). The combination of Greek and Roman activities in one architectural space was not common during Herod's time. Still, this combination is certainly compatible with the King's activities and other construction projects (Weiss 2015:105–112). According to Weiss, it is reasonable to assume that these magnificent entertainment structures were not built in wood (according to the opinions of others, such as Patrich 2003) but in stone (ibid.).

Some identify the "hippodrome" structure with the amphitheater structure mentioned by Josephus elsewhere, mainly due to the use of the word 'amphitheater,' in relation to the "hypo stadium" structure that was uncovered in Caesarea (Weiss 2015:107). Moreover, it turns out that in the second quarter of the first century BCE, hippodrome or stadium-type buildings were called 'amphitheaters' (Humphrey 1996; Patrich 2001).

The architecture of the theater building differs from the hippodrome building, mainly in the shape of the seating structure (*cavea*). In the theater, the seating structure was situated in front of the stage in a semi-circle compared to the hippodrome where the seats surrounded the competition arena on three sides, except for the side where the horse starting stalls (*carceres*) were. King Herod built buildings of this type at a number of sites in Judea, which were previously discussed in detail (Patrich 2003; Netzer 2006; Weiss 2015).

The utilization of the topographical conditions for the construction of the seat structure corresponds to the building method of Hellenistic theaters (Rune, Gebhard and Sokolicek 2015:434–454), thus fitting the dating of the structure discussed here to the Hasmonean–Early Herodian period (Stratum 3b). On the other hand, the presence of a public and monumental seating structure near and above a large public pool of water strengthens the possible connection between this unique architectural complex and Josephus' descriptions of Herod's amusement buildings and their apparent connection to the naval battle of Augustus at Actium. Naval battle reenactments took place in the Roman Empire and were called *naumachia*. These battle games were first held by Julius Caesar and the Julio-Claudian dynasty in natural or artificial water lakes and later in actual buildings such as the Colosseum in Rome (Taylor 1997).

Augustus held a *naumachia* battle in 2 BCE, and according to Frontinus, a dedicated aqueduct was built for this purpose (Frontinus, *De aquis urbis Romae* 11, 1–2: *opus naumachiae*). Therefore, in the days of Herod, amphitheater-type amusement buildings still did not fully match the architectural structure that later characterized them and, least of all, the *naumachia* buildings.

The wings of the seating structure (in the east and probably also in the west) were shorter compared to its elongated northern wing, and they were designed to focus the spectators' gaze on the center of the Birket al-Hamra. At the site above, the remains of a deep water pool were uncovered, the northern side of which can currently be estimated to be about 35 m long and the eastern side to be about 30 m long. The pool received its water both from the surface runoff that flowed in the winter along Jerusalem's central valley, also known as the Tyropoeon valley, and from the excess channel of the Siloam pool (Silwan Pool) at the outlet of the Siloam tunnel (Szanton 2023) which drew its large volume of water from the Gihon Spring.

## ■ Conclusion

The findings of the new excavation work at Birket al-Hamra provide a renewed and multi-layered view of the site. Examining the relationship between the monumental seating structure and the pool remains that were uncovered at its foot, make it possible to understand the stairs—in the light of Josephus' descriptions on the one hand, and the hydraulic and topographic features that exist on the site and in its surroundings on the other hand—as a seating structure. In light of the scarcity of historical and archaeological information, it is possible to suggest with due caution that initially this architectural complex was possibly used by Herod as a space in which he held games, competitions, and naval battles (*naumachia*) in honor of his patron Augustus, who, as Herod knew well, rose to prominence after his victory over Herod's previous patron (Marcus Antonius) in the naval battle at Actium.

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